

IN CONTEXT

The Women's Social and Political Union

Campaigns to secure votes for British women gained momentum in the 19th century, with several suffrage organizations lobbying Parliament for change. In 1903, frustrated by lack of success, a more militant group was founded in Manchester, led by Emmeline Pankhurst (1858–1928). The Women's Social and Political Union (WSPU) advocated direct action and civil disobedience, and the suffragettes were prepared to break the law in order to achieve their goal. Many of the women were imprisoned, and force-fed when they continued their protest by means of hunger strikes. From 1910 to 1912, Smyth gave up music to focus her attention on the WSPU, although she composed their anthem in 1911.



EMMELINE PANKHURST, ACTIVIST AND COFOUNDER OF THE WSPU

Ethel Mary Smyth was born in 1868 in Sidcup, Kent, at that time one of the most conservative of London suburbs. Her middle-class upbringing reflected the Victorian idea that a woman's